Education Endowment Foundation

Special Educational Needs in Mainstream Schools
Summary of recommendations

1
Create a positive and supportive environment for all pupils, without exception.



- An inclusive school removes barriers to learning and participation, provides an education that is appropriate to pupils' needs, and promotes high standards and the fulfilment of potential for all pupils.

Schools should:

- Promote positive relationships, active engagement, and wellbeing for all pupils.
- Ensure all pupils can access the best possible teaching.
- Adopt a positive and proactive approach to behaviour, as described in the EEF's **Improving Behaviour in Schools** guidance report.

2
Build an ongoing, holistic understanding of your pupils and their needs.



- Schools should aim to understand individual pupil's learning needs using the graduated approach of 'assess, plan, do, review' approach.
- Assessment should be regular and purposeful rather than a one-off event, and should seek input from parents and carers as well as the pupil themselves and specialist professionals.
- Teachers need to feel empowered and trusted to use the information they collect to make a decision about the next steps for teaching in schools.

3
Ensure all pupils have access to high quality teaching.



- To a great extent, good teaching for pupils with SEND is good teaching for all.
- Searching for a 'magic bullet' can distract teachers from the powerful strategies they often already possess.
- The research suggests a group of teaching strategies that teachers should consider emphasising for pupils with SEND. Teachers should develop a repertoire of these strategies they can use flexibly in response to the needs of all pupils:
  - flexible grouping
  - cognitive and metacognitive strategies
  - explicit instruction
  - using technology
  - scaffolding

4
Complement high quality teaching with carefully selected small-group and one-to-one interventions.



- Small-group and one-to-one interventions can be a powerful tool but must be used carefully. Ineffective use of interventions can create a barrier to the inclusion of pupils with SEND.
- High quality teaching should reduce the need for extra support, but it is likely that some pupils will require high quality, structured, targeted interventions to make progress.
- The intensity of intervention (from universal to targeted to specialist) should increase with need.
- Interventions should be carefully targeted through identification and assessment of need.
- Interventions should be applied using the principles of effective implementation described in the EEF's guidance report **A School's Guide to Implementation.**

5
Work effectively with teaching assistants.



- Effective deployment of teaching assistants (TAs) is critical. School leaders should pay careful attention to the roles of TAs and ensure they have a positive impact on pupils with SEND.
- TAs should supplement, not replace, teaching from the classroom teacher.
- The EEF's guidance report **Deployment of Teaching Assistants** provides detailed recommendations.

Read more

Special Educational Needs in Mainstream Schools guidance report